

done the binary system of having vocational education as a separate stream almost a decade ago. But India which adapted the model from them continues to follow it. Says Agarwal: "We need to start focusing on skills and get rid of the colonial baggage of producing mainly liberal arts graduates. We need to create pathways that enable students to move from vocational education to higher education after working for a few years." NIT's Pawar says it is time to get rid of the caste system that has developed in education where if a person gets off the train to do a vocational course, the system doesn't permit him to get on the higher education wagon again. Agarwal calls for integrating the two

Cut-off marks for top Delhi colleges in 2009

Science St. Stephen's

Physics-94.33 per cent PCM

Chemistry-92.33 per cent PCM

Arts

Lady Shri Ram College-

BA -90.5

English (H) 91 per cent

Pol Science -90.5 per cent

Commerce SRCC

B Com (H) 95.25-98.75

Economics (H) 93.5-96.5

History (H) 87 per cent

Sociology-91.5

systems and upgrading the status of vocational institutions to that of university levels. Sibal wants a massive expansion in vocational courses much as China did. Jadhav says: "India should focus on skilling its blue-colored workforce as they would help the country to develop a significant competitive edge."

Reduce School Dropouts

You cannot develop a 21st century university system if your school education is still in the 19th century. The good news is that India's efforts to improve and expand the physical infrastructure for schools are succeeding as recent expert reports reveal. In 1996-97, the Public Report on Basic Education, PROBE, a team of independent experts, visited 200 villages in undivided Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh to survey primary schools. Ten years later in 2006 they revisited the same villages to see the change. They found that school enrolment had risen sharply and now ranged from 80 to 95 per cent in the age group of six to 12 years. School infrastructure too had vastly improved with the proportion of schools with at least two pucca rooms going up from 24 to 84 per cent. Three-fourths of the schools had drinking water facilities and 60 per cent had toilet fa-



**STUDENTS CHECK OUT
ADMISSION LISTS**

cilities. But the real problem was that as A.K. Shiva Kumar, a PROBE team member, says: "The quality of education still remains abysmally low and the phenomenon of idle classrooms was evident in half the sample schools where there was no teaching activity on. Even in the schools with teachers, mindless rote learning dominated and the results were lacklustre." Pitroda calls for ending the chalk and blackboard era and harnessing technology to transform elementary education in rural India.

In urban areas on the other hand, apart from shortage of skilled teachers, the major complaint was the stressful secondary board examinations. Arun Kapur, director of the Delhi-based Vasant Valley School, says: "We should stop using Board examinations as a fil-

tration plant for admitting students to colleges. The curse of obtaining high marks has seen a rise in students committing suicide across the country because of the stress. Universities have to evolve an independent evaluation system that goes beyond just using marks from board exams." Sibal said making "examination trauma-free" was one of his priorities and planned to scrap the 10th Board exams.

There is also a growing demand to free the crippling government control over school education and introduce massive privatisation including making it a for-profit sector. The key is to nurture excellence instead of, as Basu points out, "spending a disproportionate amount of energy trying to curb the lack of it." Will India ever learn? ■

EXPERTSPEAK

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ARUN KAPUR

Director, Vasant Valley School



"The quality of education in rural schools still remains abysmally low with teacher absenteeism chronic."

A.K. SHIVA KUMAR

Development economist

